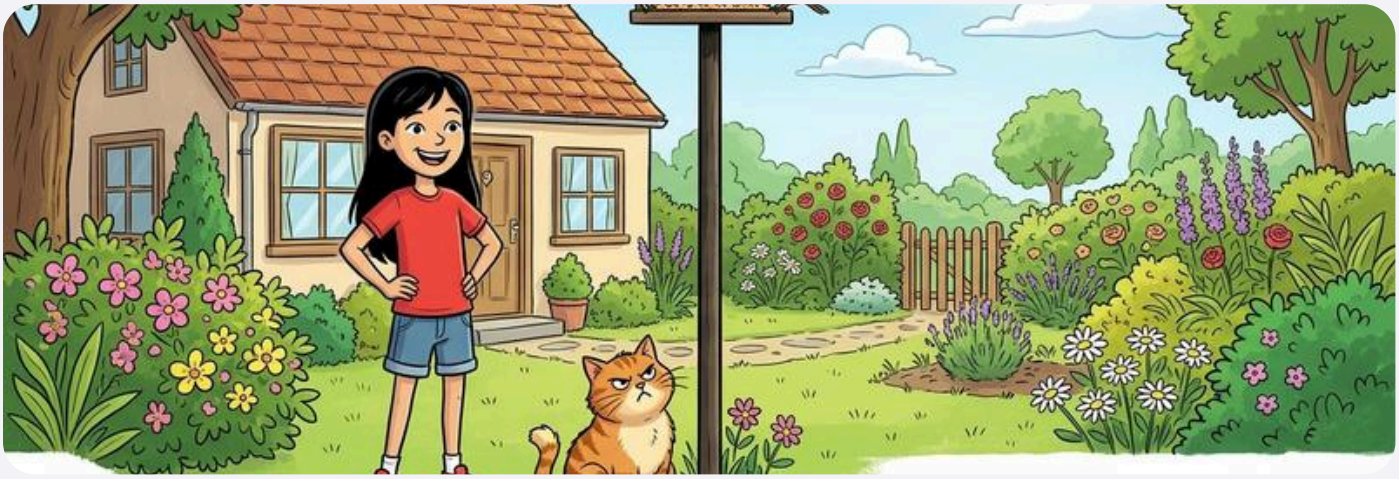
Brave or Afraid? The Secrets of Fear

Day 1 · Reading (1 of 2)

What to do: Read it aloud, one paragraph each. Stop at every blue word: can anybody explain it?

Vocabulary topic: Fear and courage
20 new words (in blue) · EEW 1, Unit 1 · read about fear and talk about what scares you



easy parts harder parts (most new words are here)

Everybody is **afraid** of something. Some people are afraid of spiders. Some are afraid of the dark, of flying or of speaking in public. If you are afraid, you are not weak. Fear is normal, and it is very old.

Thousands of years ago, fear helped people to stay alive. When a person saw a big animal near the camp, the body reacted in one **moment**: the heart beat faster, the muscles got ready, and the person ran away or looked for a place to **hide**. Today we do not meet many wild animals, but the body still reacts in the same way in an exam or in a dark street.

Scientists say that fear starts in a small part of the brain, the amygdala. It sends a signal before you can even think. That is why you jump when somebody shouts behind you. When you **finally** understand that there is no danger, the brain slowly calms down. Many experts **agree** that fear and excitement feel almost the same in the body: the difference is only in the mind. A roller coaster is a good example. The same people who scream at the top often **reply** “Again!” at the **bottom**.

Do you know the most common fear in the world? It is not spiders or snakes. It is speaking in front of a **lot** of people. Even famous actors feel nervous before a show.

Here are some fun facts. When you are very afraid, your heart can beat twice as fast. Your hands can get cold, because the blood goes to the big muscles. Your eyes get bigger, to see more. Your body is like a small alarm system, and it works in less than a second.

Some people like fear. They watch horror films, ride the fastest roller coasters and jump from planes with a parachute. Why? Because the body makes the same chemicals when we are afraid and when we are excited. After the scary moment, we feel great.

Brave or Afraid? The Secrets of Fear

Day 1 · Reading (2 of 2)

What to do: After reading: which paragraphs were easy, which were hard? Which blue words did you know already?

Animals know about fear, too, and some of them are very **clever**. A small animal cannot **attack** a big one, so it uses a **trick**. The opossum falls down and plays dead. The octopus changes color and disappears into the rocks. The lizard drops its tail: the tail keeps moving, the enemy looks at the tail, and the lizard runs away and stays **safe**. Scientists call this reaction “fight, flight or freeze”.

There is an old story about a rabbit and a lion. The lion was big and strong, and all the animals in the forest were afraid of him. The rabbit was small, but he was not stupid. He had a plan. You can read the whole story in your book, Unit 1.

Fear can also be used by other people. In many old stories, a **cruel** king makes everybody afraid. In real life, the best leaders are not cruel: they make a **promise** and keep it. A group of men who **hunt** in the **middle** of the night must trust each other. Firefighters are afraid, too, but they are **pleased** when they save somebody, and that feeling is stronger than the fear.

How can you control your fear? Here are four easy ideas. One: breathe slowly. In for four seconds, out for six. Two: talk to a friend. A friend can help you see the problem in a different way. Three: do it a little at a time. If you are afraid of dogs, start with a photo, then a small dog, then a big dog. Four: sleep **well** the night before an exam.

Fear and anger are often together. When people feel afraid, they sometimes become **angry**, because anger feels stronger than fear. A driver who almost has an accident shouts at the other car. A child who is lost in a shop shouts at the parents when they **arrive**. It is not nice, but it is very human.

So the next time you feel afraid, remember: your body is trying to keep you **safe**. Say hello to your fear, and then, step by step, do the thing anyway. That is what brave people do. They are not people without fear. They are people who are afraid and go on.

The 20 words

Day 1 · Vocabulary table · Topic: Fear and courage

What to do: Book: 4000 EEW 1, Unit 1, pages 8–11. Copy the words you do not know into the copybook.

Word	Meaning	По-русски	Example
afraid adj.	full of fear	испуганный; бояться	My little brother is afraid of the dark.
agree v.	have the same opinion	соглашаться	I agree with you. It is a good idea.
angry adj.	feeling that you want to shout	сердитый, злой	Mom is angry because my room is a mess.
arrive v.	get to a place	прибывать, приезжать	The bus arrives at 8 o'clock.
attack v.	try to hurt someone	нападать	Lions attack zebras.
bottom n.	the lowest part	низ, дно	The ball is at the bottom of the stairs.
clever adj.	quick to learn and understand	умный, сообразительный	She is a clever girl: she solves every puzzle.
cruel adj.	not kind, making others suffer	жестокий	Don't be cruel to animals.
finally adv.	at last, after a long time	наконец	After a long trip, we are finally home.
hide v.	go where nobody can see you	прятать(ся)	The children hide behind the trees.
hunt v.	look for animals to kill and eat	охотиться	Cats hunt mice at night.
lot n.	a large number or amount	много (a lot of)	I have a lot of friends.
middle n.	the center	середина	The puppy is in the middle of the circle.
moment n.	a very short time	момент, миг	Wait a moment, please!
pleased adj.	happy about something	довольный	The teacher is pleased with our work.
promise v./n.	say that you will really do something	обещать; обещание	I promise to help you.
reply v./n.	answer	отвечать; ответ	Please reply to my message.
safe adj.	not in danger	безопасный, в безопасности	Wear a helmet and be safe.
trick n.	a clever act to fool someone	фокус, хитрость	The magician shows a great trick.
well adv.	in a good way	хорошо; ну	She sings very well.

More on the topic

Day 1 · Topic: Fear and courage · more words

What to do: Choose 5 collocations to learn. Use the reserve words when a student already knows the main ones.

Collocations: words that go together

be afraid of…	бояться чего-то
keep a promise	сдержать обещание
play a trick on…	разыграть кого-то
be angry with…	сердиться на…
in the middle of the night	посреди ночи
at the bottom of…	на дне, внизу
agree with… · agree to do	соглашаться с… · согласиться сделать
reply to a message	ответить на сообщение
be pleased with…	быть довольным…
arrive at the station · in London	прибыть на станцию · в Лондон
feel safe	чувствовать себя в безопасности
hide from…	прятаться от…

Phrasal verbs

run away	убежать	The kitten was scared and ran away.
back away	медленно отступить	If a dog barks, back away slowly.
stand up to	дать отпор, противостоять	She always stands up to bullies.
give up	сдаться	Don’t give up! Try again.
cheer up	взбодриться	Cheer up! Tomorrow is Friday.
speak up	говорить громче; высказаться	Please speak up: I cannot hear you.

Reserve words: for students who know the 20 already, or if you prefer another word

brave	храбрый	**shy**	застенчивый
courage	смелость	**worry**	беспокоиться
danger	опасность	**escape**	сбежать
panic	паника	**threat**	угроза
scared	напуганный	**bite**	кусать

What to read next · 4000 Essential English Words

This week: **Book 1, Unit 1, “The Lion and the Rabbit”**, pages 8–13. Next: **Unit 2, “The Laboratory”**, pages 14–19. More about feelings: **Unit 4, “The Dog’s Bell”**, pages 26–31.